



Silverleaf Academy

SOCIAL MEDIA POLICY

The school recognizes and embraces the numerous benefits and opportunities that social media offers. While employees are encouraged to engage, collaborate and innovate through social media, they should also be aware that there are some associated risks, especially around issues of safeguarding, bullying, and personal reputation.

Purpose of the policy

- The purpose of this policy is to encourage good practice, to protect the school and its employees, and to promote the effective use of social media as part of the school activities.
- This policy covers personal and professional use of social media and aims to encourage its safe use by the school and its employees.
- The policy applies regardless of whether the social media is accessed using the school's IT facilities and equipment, or equipment belonging to members of staff.
- Personal communications via social media accounts that are likely to have a negative impact on professional standards or the school's reputation are within the scope of this policy.
- This policy covers all individuals working at all levels and grades, including full-time and part-time employees, fixed-term employees, and agency workers.

Roles, responsibilities, and procedure

Employees should:

- be aware of their online reputation and recognize that their online activity can be seen by others including parents, pupils, and colleagues on social media;
- ensure that any use of social media is carried out in line with this policy and other relevant policies, i.e. those of the employer;
- be aware that any excessive use of social media in school may result in disciplinary action;
- be responsible for their words and actions in an online environment. They are therefore advised to consider whether any comment, photograph, or video that they are about to post on a social networking site is something that they want pupils, colleagues, other employees of the, or even future employers, to read. If in doubt, don't post it!



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Managers are responsible for:

- addressing any concerns and or questions employees may have on the use of social media;
- operating within the boundaries of this policy and ensuring that all staff understands the standards of behavior expected of them.

Human resources (HR) is responsible for:

- giving specialist advice on the use of social media;
- implementing and reviewing this policy.

Definition of social media

Social media is a broad term for any kind of online platform which enables people to directly interact with each other. It allows people to share information, ideas and views. Examples of social media include blogs, Facebook, LinkedIn, Twitter, Google+, Instagram, Myspace, Flickr, and YouTube.

Acceptable use

Employees should be aware that content uploaded to social media is not private. Even if you restrict it to 'friends, there is still capacity for it to be re-posted or distributed beyond the intended recipients. Therefore, employees using social media should conduct themselves with professionalism and respect.

A. General guidelines

There is a specific way to treat each social media, based on our companies image here is how:

Instagram & Facebook: In these platforms free to post all regulated posts based on enrolments, celebrations, public holidays, special features and so on but we cannot use these platforms for fundraising purposes, due to our companies policies.



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LinkedIn & Twitter: we can use these platforms for all purposes even for fundraising purposes since they abide by our companies policies.

The general guidelines of etiquette for employees, parents, or students who use school-related social media include:

- Be aware of and comply with the School Acceptable Use Agreement.
- Be aware of and comply with the School Internet Publishing Guidelines.
- Be aware of the permanency of the Internet and think before you post. Once something is sent out, it may be permanent and unable to be retracted.
- Act responsibly since everything online may be accessible to the public.
- Treat others with respect, protect confidential information and the rights of others, and obey the copyright law.
- Post positive, meaningful, and thoughtful comments.
- Disagree courteously, without disparaging comments.
- No photos of students obtained through School resources may be loaded on personal pages. Student photos posted on school-related social media must not contain the student's name.
- School employees must not "friend" students on personal social media; and must avoid overly personal emails, texts, or communications with students on school-related social media, excepting members of the immediate family.

Employees should not upload any content to social media sites that:

- is confidential to the school or its staff
- amounts to bullying
- amounts to unlawful discrimination, harassment, or victimization
- brings the school into disrepute
- contains lewd, sexually explicit, threatening, or similarly inappropriate or offensive comments, images, or video clips
- undermines the reputation of the school and or individuals
- is defamatory or knowingly false
- breaches copyright
- is in any other way unlawful.



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B. Employees and Social Media

To protect School employees, students, parents, and school resources, the School requires all employees who access or create social networking sites through School resources to abide by the following:

- Access to social media sites using school resources should be for instructional purposes directly related to employment responsibilities and/or educator's curriculum.
- What is written should provide value by being thought-provoking and building a sense of community.
- What is written should help people improve their knowledge and skills, solve problems, or understand situations.
- Only comment on things about which you are well informed.
- What is written should invite discussion without inflaming others or demeaning them.
- Different points of view are appropriate if they are expressed with respect for others.
- Be honest in your communication and clear about your role.
- Clearly identify yourself as an employee/educator
- If you have a vested interest in what is being discussed, identify it.
- Establish and maintain a professional image.
- Post only what you want the world to see; even in private sites, "friends" may copy your post and then make it public.
- Write the way you would speak in your professional assignment.
- Adhere to the standards of professional practice and maintain appropriate school relationships at all times.
- Maintain a public, professional relationship with students and their parents.
- Do not violate privacy, confidentiality, or legal guidelines.
- Protect yourself and others by not revealing private, confidential, or sensitive information.
- All use of social media must comply with privacy requirements
- Personally identifiable student information, including photographs, shall not be included in personal social media. Ask permission before posting pictures or videos of others.
- Pictures and videos of students are education records and require parent notification of directory information prior to posting. Additionally, any posting of a student photo or video may not include the student's name.
- Never comment on anything related to legal matters or litigation.
- Report inappropriate online behavior.



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- Take responsibility to ensure that student posts that violate laws or school policies are removed immediately and appropriate disciplinary action is taken.

Employees should be aware of both professional and social boundaries and should not therefore accept or invite 'friend' requests from pupils or ex-pupils under the age of 18, or from parents on their personal social media accounts such as Facebook. All communication with parents via social media should be through the school's social media accounts. Employees should note that the use of social media accounts during lesson time is not permitted.

Safeguarding

The use of social networking sites introduces a range of potential safeguarding risks to children and young people.

Potential risks can include, but are not limited to:

- online bullying;
- grooming, exploitation, or stalking;
- exposure to inappropriate material or hateful language;
- encouraging violent behavior, self-harm or risk-taking.

In order to mitigate these risks, there are steps you can take to promote safety online:

- You should not use any information in an attempt to locate or meet a child.
- Ensure that any messages, photos or information comply with existing policies.

Reporting safeguarding concerns

- Any content or online activity which raises a safeguarding concern must be reported to the lead safeguarding officer in the school.
- Any online concerns should be reported as soon as identified as urgent steps may need to be taken to support the child.



- With regard to personal safeguarding, you should report any harassment or abuse you receive online while using your work accounts.

Reporting, responding and recording cyberbullying incidents

- Staff should never engage with cyberbullying incidents. If in the course of your employment with this school, you discover a website containing inaccurate, inappropriate or inflammatory written material relating to you, or images of you which have been taken and or which are being used without your permission, you should immediately report this to a senior manager at your school.
- Staff should keep any records of the abuse such as text, emails, voicemails, website or social media. If appropriate, screen prints of messages or web pages could be taken and the time, date and address of site should be recorded.

Breaches of this policy

Any member of staff suspected of committing a breach of this policy (or if complaints are received about unacceptable use of social networking that has potentially breached this policy) will be investigated in accordance with the school's bullying or disciplinary procedure. The member of staff will be expected to cooperate with the school's investigation which may involve:

- handing over relevant passwords and login details;
- printing a copy or obtaining a screenshot of the alleged unacceptable content;
- determining that the responsibility or source of the content was in fact the member of staff.

The seriousness of the breach will be considered including the nature of the content, how long the content remained visible on the social media site, the potential for recirculation by others and the impact on the school or the individuals concerned. Staff should be aware that actions online can be in breach of the harassment/IT/equality policies and any online breaches of these policies may also be treated as conduct issues in accordance with the disciplinary procedure. If the outcome of an investigation leads to disciplinary action, the consequences will be dealt with in accordance with the appropriate procedures. Serious breaches could result in the dismissal of the employee. Where conduct is considered to be unlawful, the school will report the matter to the police and other external agencies.

Monitoring and review



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If the manager reasonably believes that an employee has breached this policy, from time to time the school will monitor or record communications that are sent or received from within the school network.

This policy will be reviewed on a yearly basis and, in accordance with the following, on an as-and-when-required basis:

- legislative changes;
- good practice guidance;
- case law;
- significant incidents reported.